

MADRE manual

How to work with your AI agents

MADRE 1.0.5

In MADRE you work with the AIs you already use: Codex, Claude, Gemini, Cursor or OpenCode. You write to them, they read your project, and you decide what they may change.

If you have never used an AI, start with «Install MADRE» and go in order. If you use them already, go straight to what you need: each section ends with what is worth knowing once you have some practice.

FOUR WORDS BEFORE YOU START

Agent

An AI that works on your project. Codex, Claude and Gemini are agents.

Project

A folder on your Mac. Each one has its chats and its memory.

Permission

What the agent may do with that message: only talk, create files or change them.

Memory

What MADRE remembers about your project, so you do not have to explain it every time.

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01

Install MADRE

MADRE installs with one command and opens in your browser. No account, no card.

```
$ npx @jossuealcala/madre
```

1. Install Node.js 22.5 or newer from nodejs.org. If you have it, skip this step.
2. Open the Terminal, paste the command above and press ↵.
3. MADRE opens in your browser, in Home. Next time, use the same command.

TRY IT

To know whether you have Node already, type `node --version` in the Terminal. If it says v22.5 or a higher number, you are set.

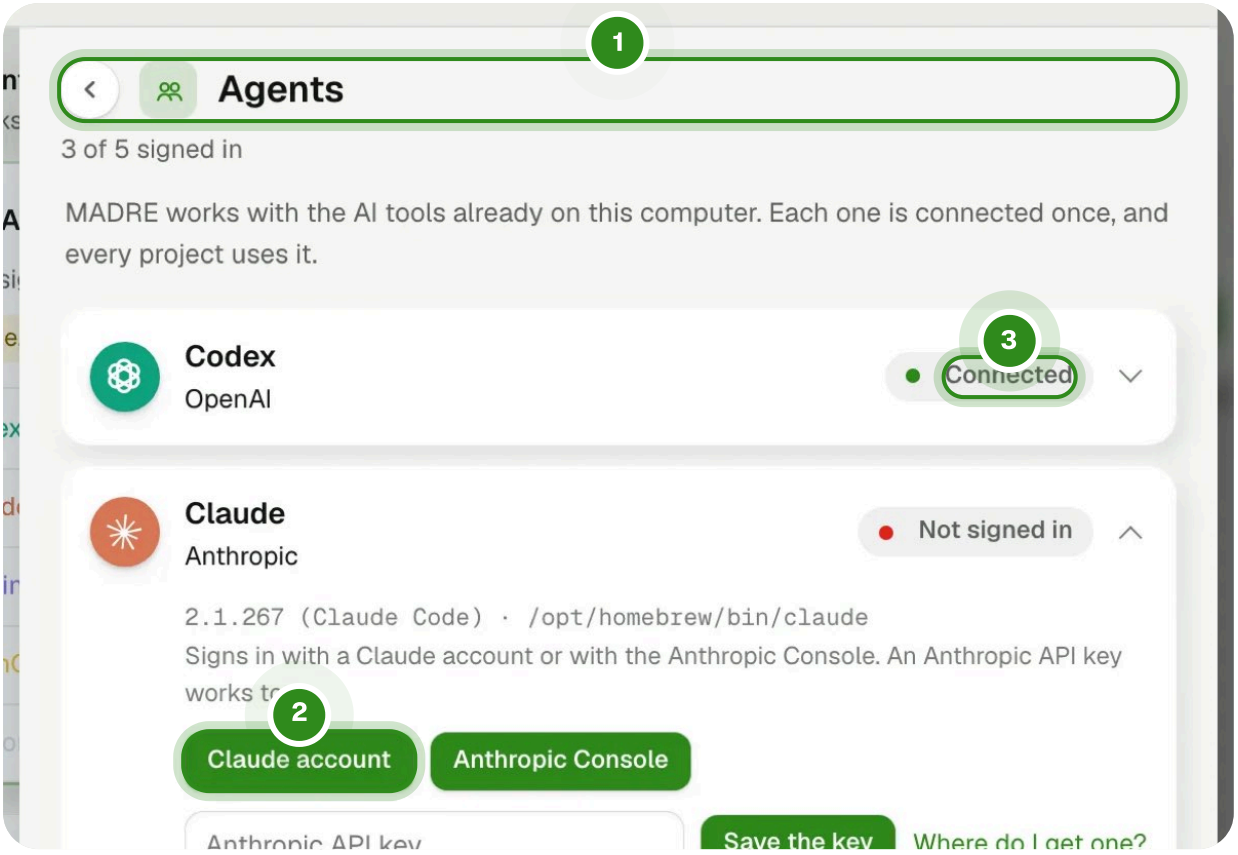
IF YOU KNOW THE BASICS

MADRE does not keep your passwords: it uses the sessions your agents already have on your Mac. With `--port 4800` it opens on another port.

02

Connect your agents

An agent is an AI such as Codex, Claude or Gemini. You connect it once and every project uses it. One is enough to start.



1. In Home, open Settings › Agents. The first time, MADRE shows it to you on its own.
2. Open an agent that says «Not signed in» and press its key, such as «Claude account». You sign in with your account on the provider's page. If you do not have it, you will see Install.
3. Once it says «Connected», you can talk to it.

TRY IT

If you use ChatGPT already, connect Codex with that same account: it is the quickest.

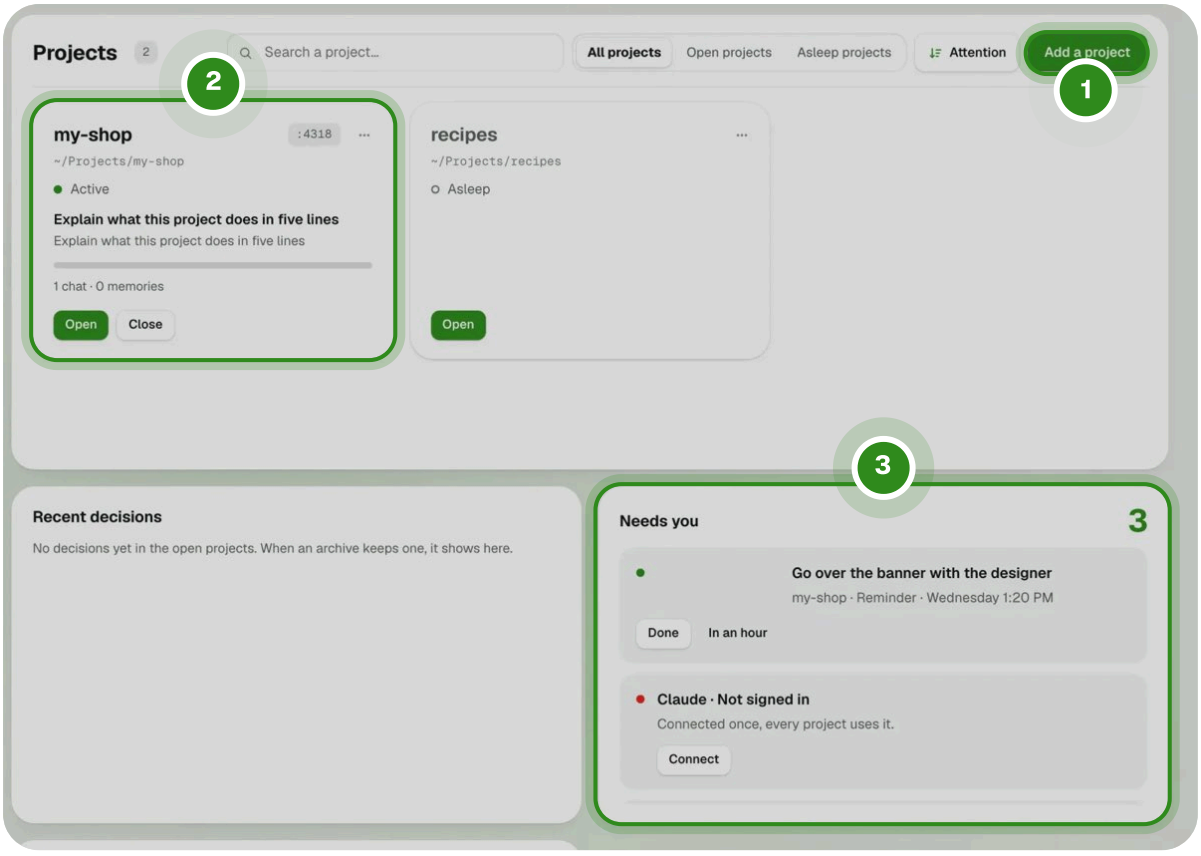
IF YOU KNOW THE BASICS

Each agent keeps its own session; MADRE does not read it. API keys (Gemini, OpenCode) are pasted on the same card, and «Prefer your terminal?» gives you the command.

03

Your first project

A project is a folder on your Mac. MADRE opens it, reads it and keeps a memory of it. Adding it changes nothing inside.



1. In Home, press «Add project» and choose the folder.
2. Its card appears. Click it to open the project.
3. «Needs you» gathers what is pending: an agent's question, a permission or a reminder.

TRY IT

No folder at hand? Make an empty one called «test» and add it.

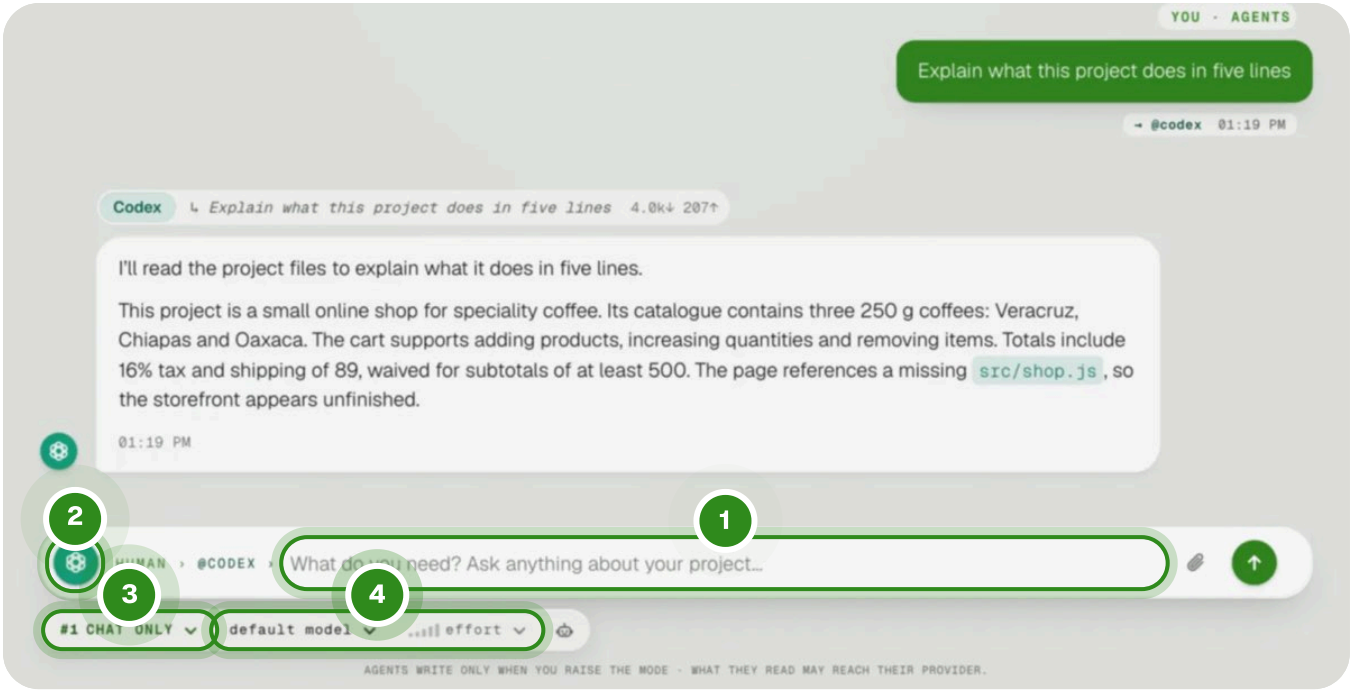
IF YOU KNOW THE BASICS

Right-click a card to pin it to the bar or take it out of MADRE; your folder stays as it is. Right-click the background to add widgets.

04

Ask an agent for something

You write at the bottom and the agent answers in the chat. You do not need to know about AI: ask the way you would ask a person.



1. Write in the box and press ↵ to send.
2. The circle on the left is the agent that will answer. Press it to choose another.
3. The tag with # is the permission. With #1 the agent reads and answers but changes nothing.
4. Beside it you choose the model and how hard it thinks. If unsure, leave them be.

TRY IT

Write: Explain what this project does in five lines.

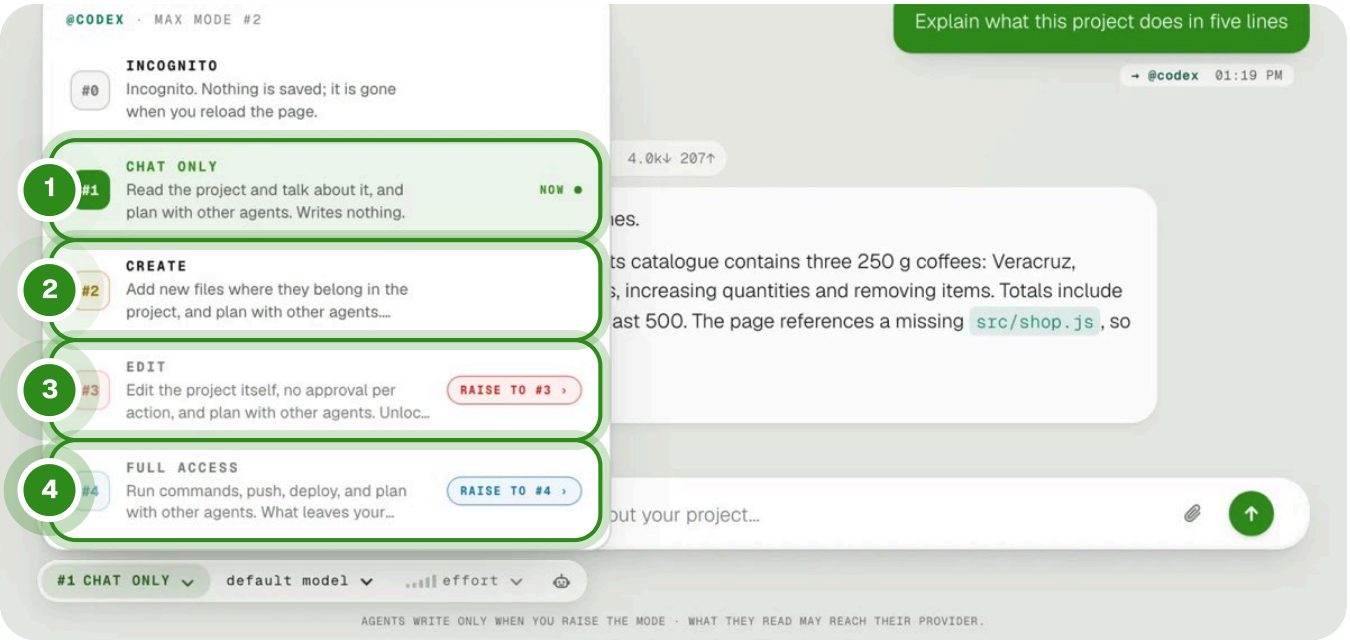
IF YOU KNOW THE BASICS

@ calls an agent, # changes the permission, ! quotes a file and / opens the commands. ⌥ ↵ makes a new line and ⌘ V pastes an image.

05

How far it may go

Every message carries a permission. Start at #1, which changes nothing, and raise it when you want the agent to work on your files.



1. #1 Chat only: reads your project and answers.
2. #2 Create: adds new files.
3. #3 Edit: changes your files. Going up to #3 asks you to confirm, and MADRE keeps a point to undo.
4. #4 Full access: runs commands and may publish. It asks you to confirm twice.

TRY IT

At #2 ask: `create a todo.md file with what is left`. The new file appears; the ones you had are not touched.

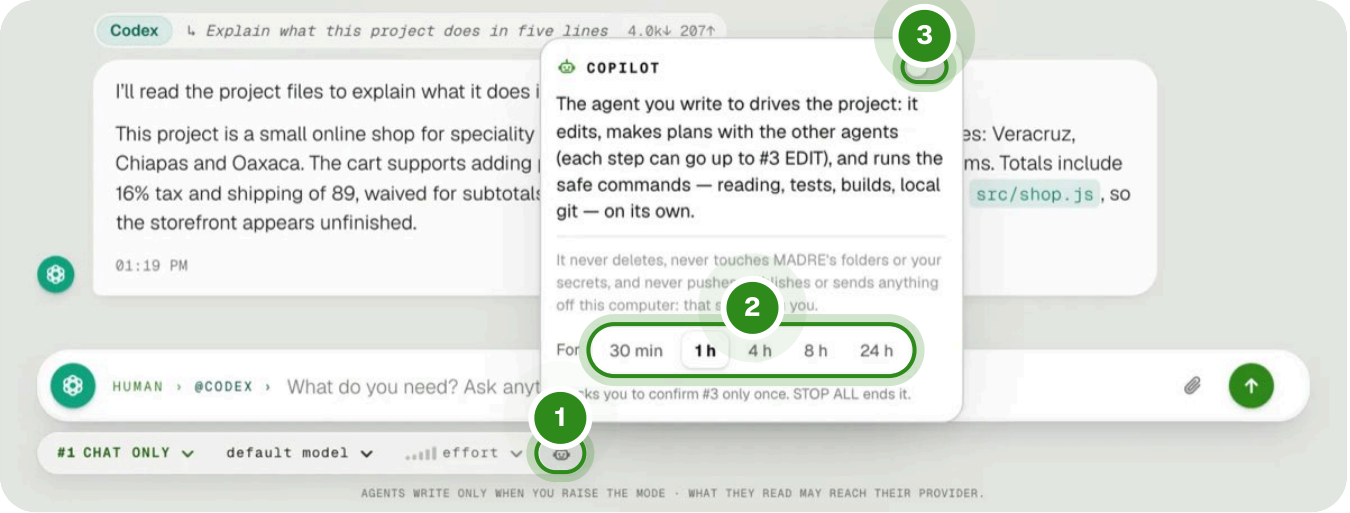
IF YOU KNOW THE BASICS

#0 Incognito talks without saving anything. Each agent's ceiling, and how you confirm, are in Settings › Permissions.

06

Let it work alone for a while

For a long job, Copilot lets the agent carry on without asking at every step.



1. Press the robot beside the box.
2. Choose for how long: from 30 minutes to 24 hours.
3. Turn it on and write the task. It asks you to confirm only once.

TRY IT

Turn it on for an hour and ask: go through every test and fix the ones that fail.

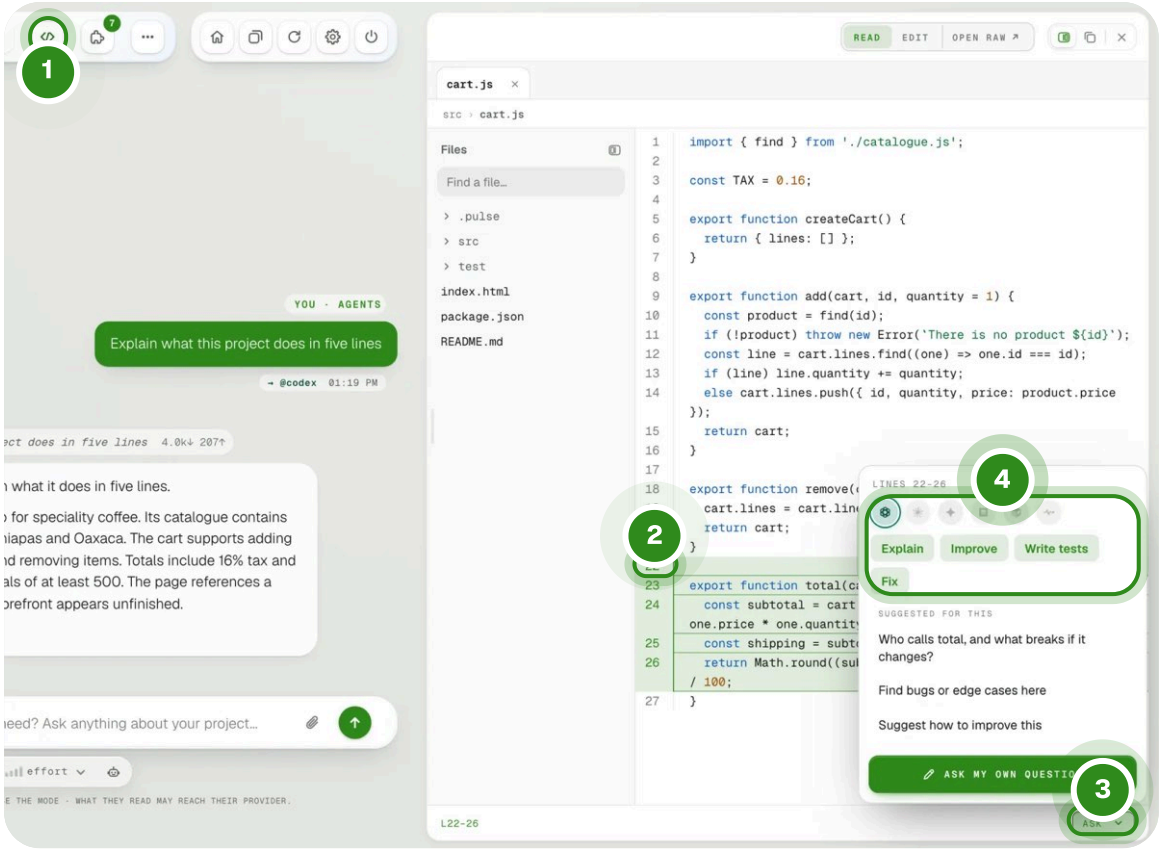
IF YOU KNOW THE BASICS

With Copilot the agent edits and runs what is safe, such as your tests. It never deletes or publishes. It stops on its own when the time is up, or with STOP ALL.

07

Look at the code

Code opens your files beside the chat. What each agent changed is marked in its colour.



1. Press Code on the bar at the top.
2. Click a line number. With ⇧ you pick several.
3. Press ASK.
4. Choose the agent and what you want: explain, improve, write tests or fix.

TRY IT

Open a file, click a line number and press ASK › Explain.

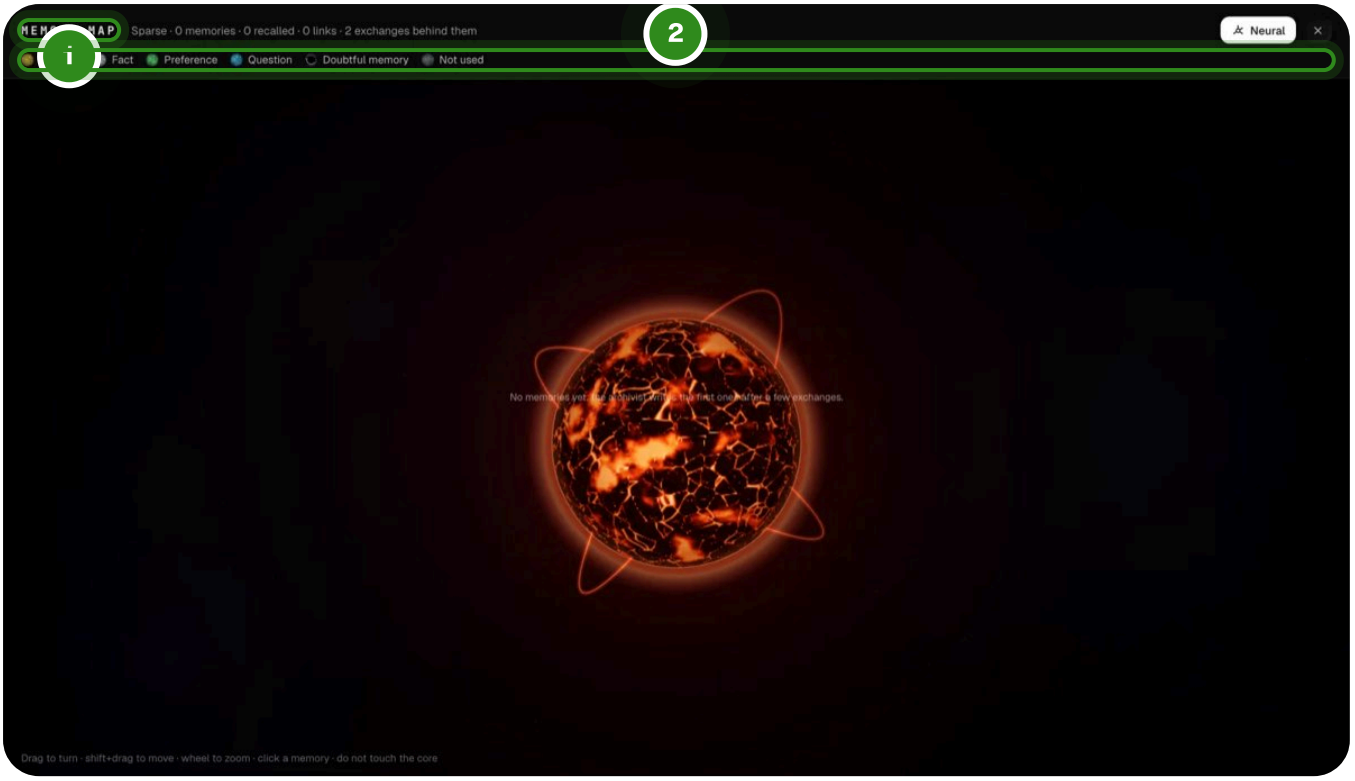
IF YOU KNOW THE BASICS

⌘ P finds a file by name. EDIT lets you write: ⌘ S saves, ⌘ F finds and ⌘ / comments.

08

The memory

MADRE remembers what gets decided in your project, so you do not have to explain it every time. All your agents read the same memory.



1. Press Memory map on the bar. It opens full screen.
2. Each star is something MADRE remembers. Its colour says whether it is a decision, a fact or a preference.
3. Click a star to read it. If it is no longer true, you forget it from there.

TRY IT

Tell an agent: `remember that prices always include tax`. Then ask another agent how the prices work.

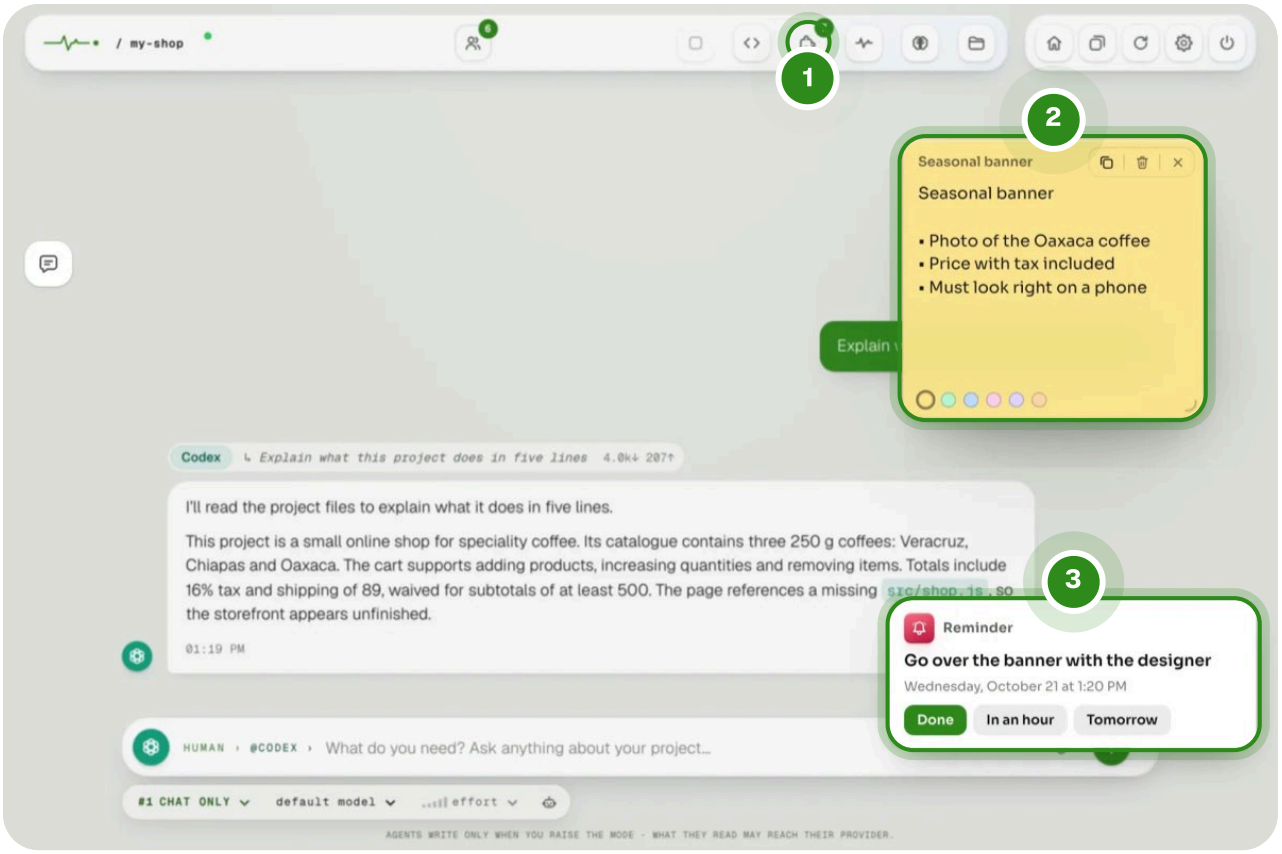
IF YOU KNOW THE BASICS

With #0 Incognito nothing is kept. With the local AI, the memory is searched by what things mean, not only by their words.

09

Notes and reminders

A note is a coloured slip stuck to your project. A reminder tells you on the day and at the hour you say.



1. Turn on Notes and Reminders in Modules.
2. Each note opens its own window: write, change the colour or throw it away.
3. When a reminder is due, MADRE shows it in the project and in «Needs you», in Home.

TRY IT

Write to an agent: `remind me tomorrow at 10 to check the banner`.

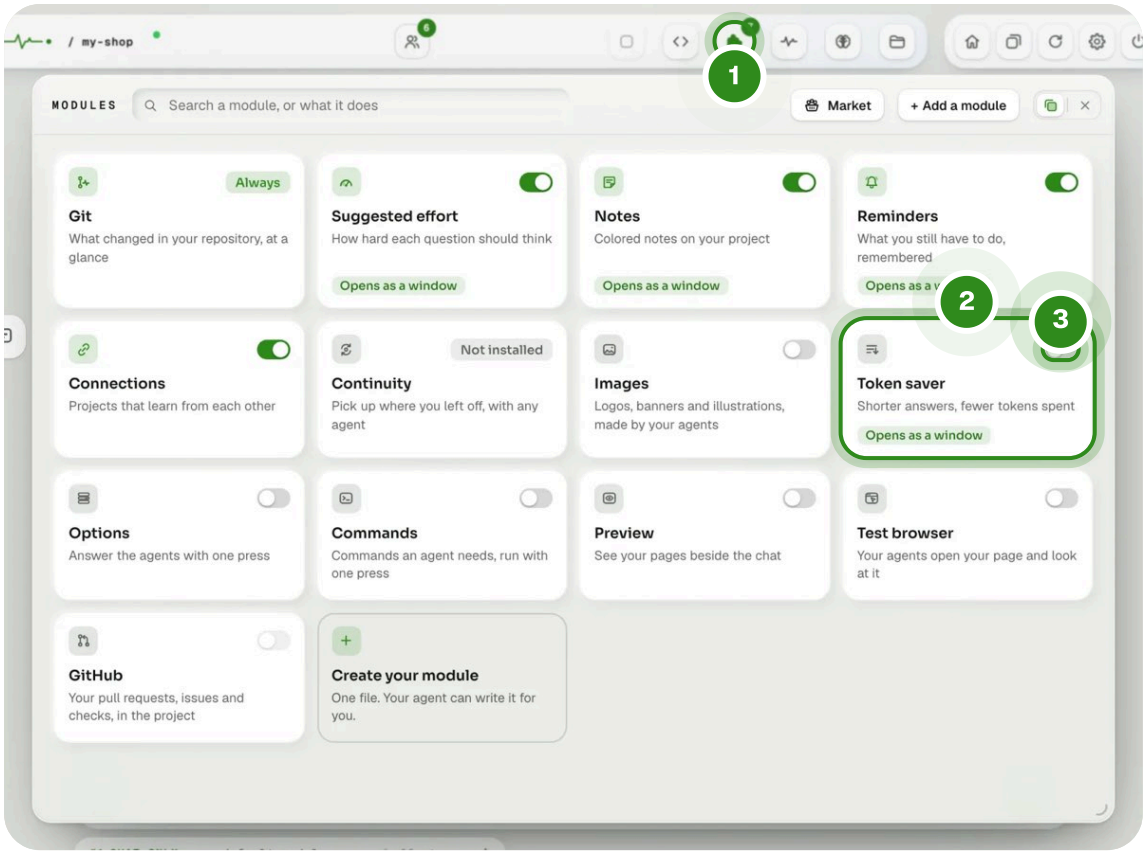
IF YOU KNOW THE BASICS

/notes and /reminders ask the agent you have chosen for the note or the reminder. If you write «I have to…», MADRE offers to keep it.

10

Modules

Features you turn on when you need them. While it is off, a module does nothing.



1. Open Modules on the project's bar.
2. Press a tile to read what it does, what it writes and what it needs.
3. Move its switch to turn it on.

TRY IT

Turn on «Token saver» and ask the same question again: the answer comes out shorter.

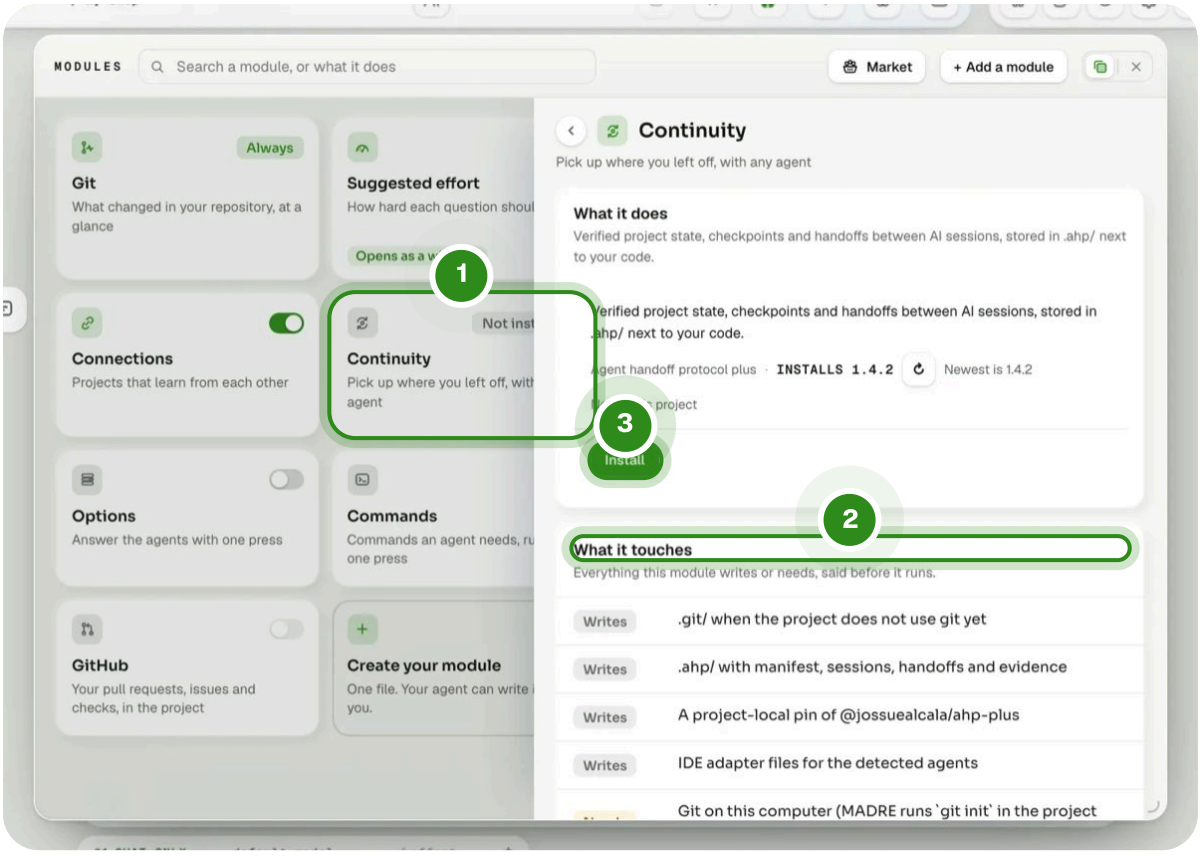
IF YOU KNOW THE BASICS

The Market, from Home, has more. On each module's page you choose all your projects or just one.

11

Continuity

Continuity keeps, inside your project, where the work stands: decisions, what is left and points to undo. If you change agent, editor or computer, the next one carries on from there.



1. In Modules, press Continuity.
2. Under «What it touches» you see what it writes: a .ahp/ folder inside your project, in plain text.
3. Press Install. Your project needs to use git, with at least one commit.

TRY IT

Install it, work a while with Codex and open the project in Claude Code, outside MADRE: it knows where you were.

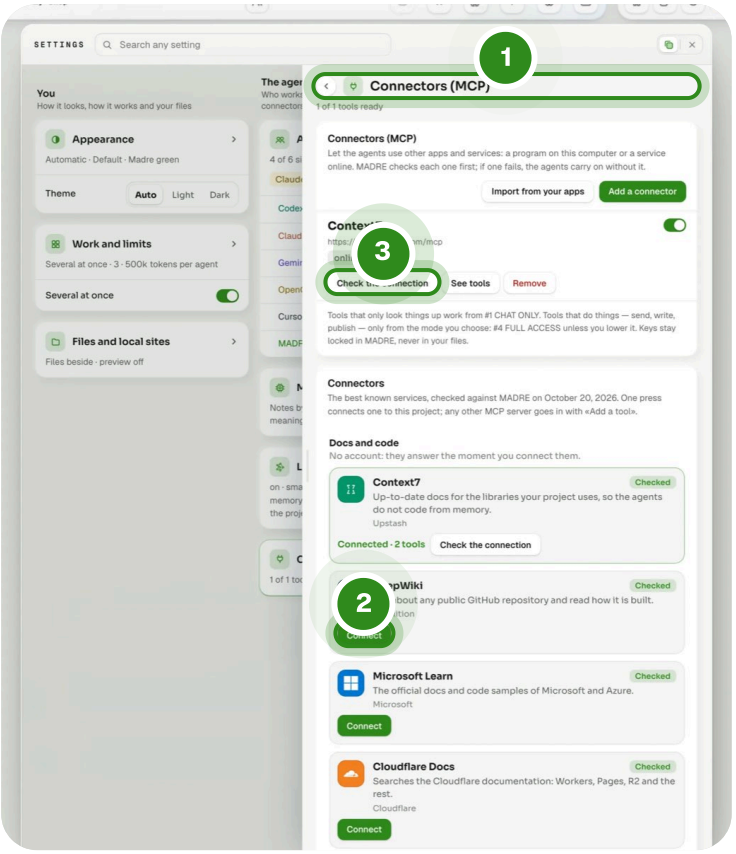
IF YOU KNOW THE BASICS

Outside MADRE it is called AHP+. Claude Code, Codex and OpenCode read it with their own files, and it travels with your repository.

12

Connectors (MCP)

A connector lets your agents use another app, such as GitHub, Notion or your calendar.



1. Open Settings › Connectors (MCP).
2. Choose one from the catalogue and press Connect. Some open their page so you can sign in.
3. Press «Check the connection» to make sure it answers.

TRY IT

Connect GitHub and ask: `which issues do I have open?`.

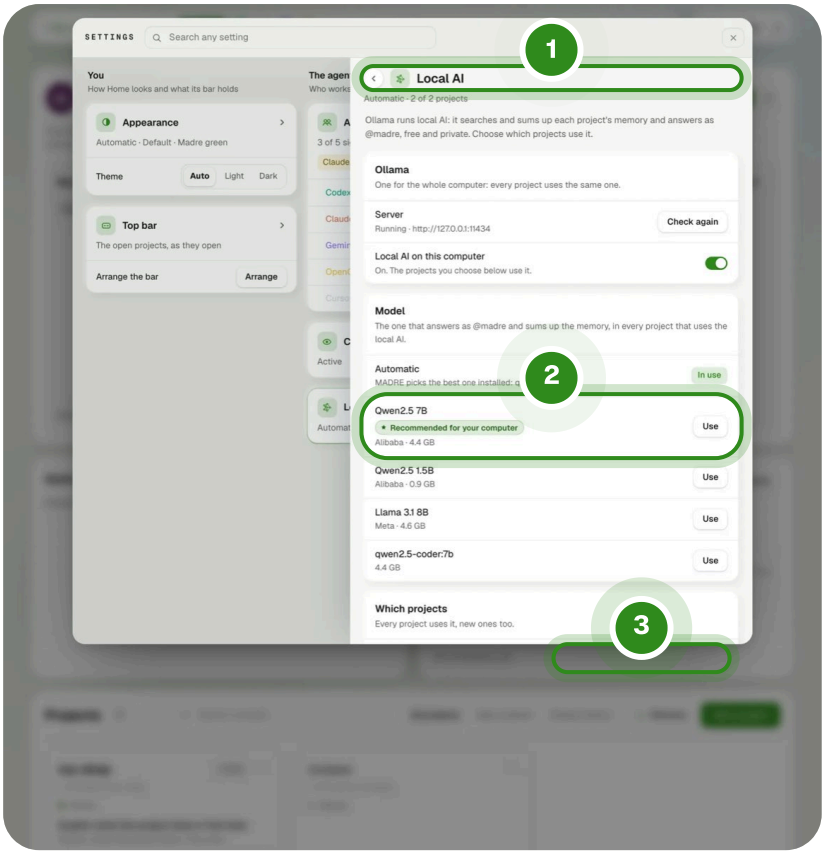
IF YOU KNOW THE BASICS

If you set them up in Claude Code, Codex, Gemini or Cursor already, «Import from your apps» brings them over.

13

AI on your Mac

An AI that runs on your machine, free and offline. MADRE uses it to keep the memory in order and as one more agent: @madre.



1. In Home, open Settings › Local AI.
2. Download the model marked «Recommended for your computer»: it is already sized for your Mac.
3. Choose which projects use it.

TRY IT

Download the recommended model and ask @madre something about your project.

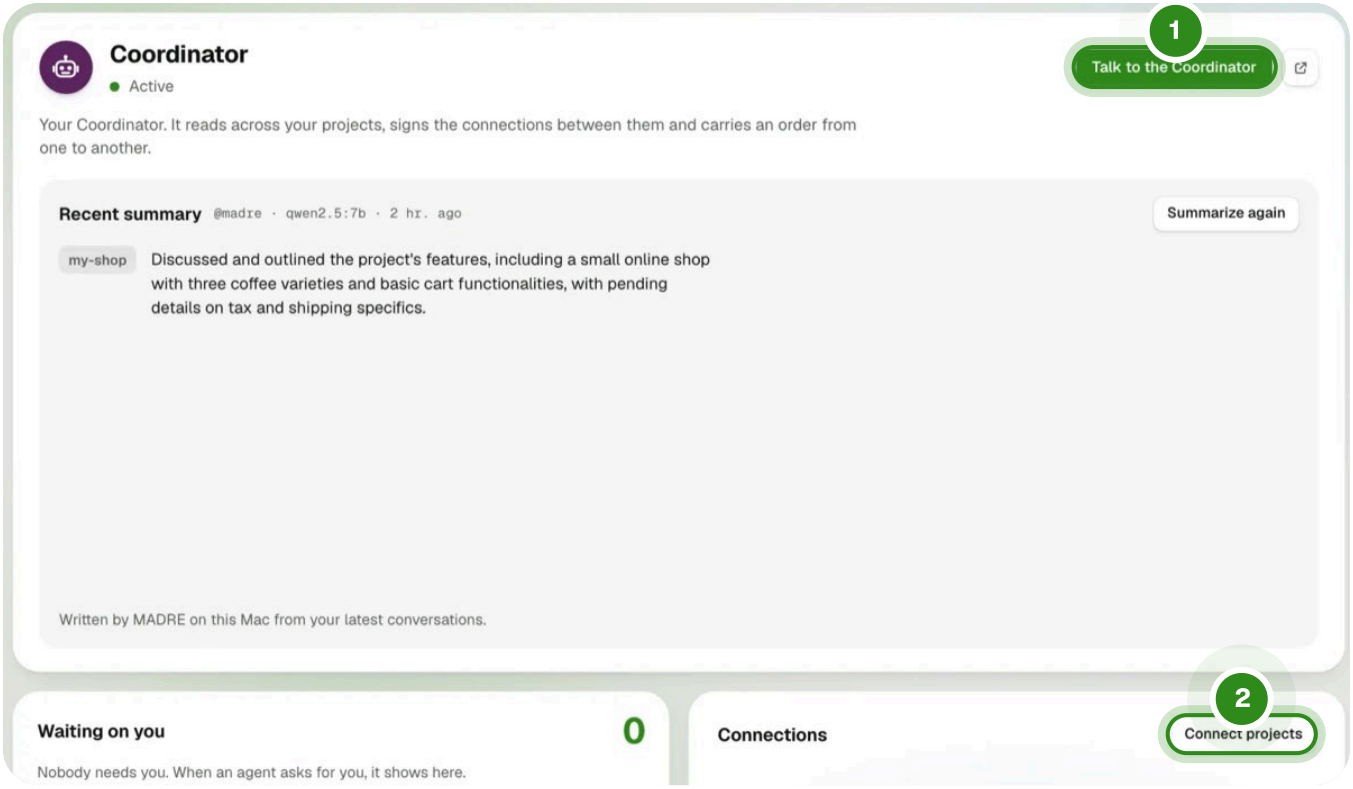
IF YOU KNOW THE BASICS

It runs on Ollama. MADRE only offers the models that fit your computer.

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Several projects at once

The Coordinator sees all your projects. With a connection, one project can look up what another learned.



1. Talk to the Coordinator from Home.
2. Make a connection between two projects. You decide what it may look up and until when.

TRY IT

In Home, ask the Coordinator: which project was I on yesterday?.

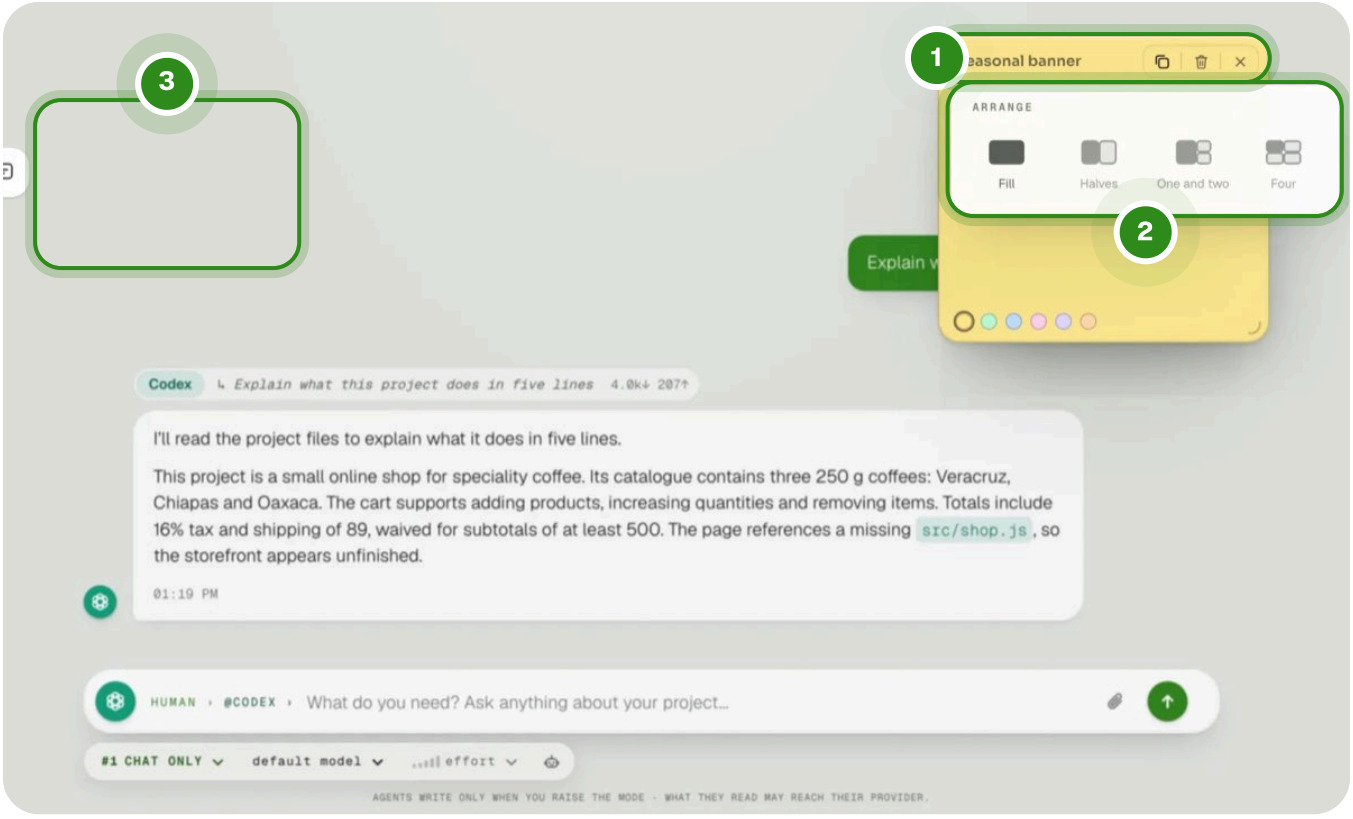
IF YOU KNOW THE BASICS

From any project you ask it with /bishop. Memory notes travel through a connection, never your files or your chats.

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Windows

Chats, notes, files and settings open as windows you move just as on your Mac.



1. Drag a window by its header.
2. Rest the pointer on its window key: it offers half, quarter or full screen.
3. Click the background to set them all aside; click one's edge to bring it back.

TRY IT

Open a note and click the project's background: the note steps aside. Another click brings it back.

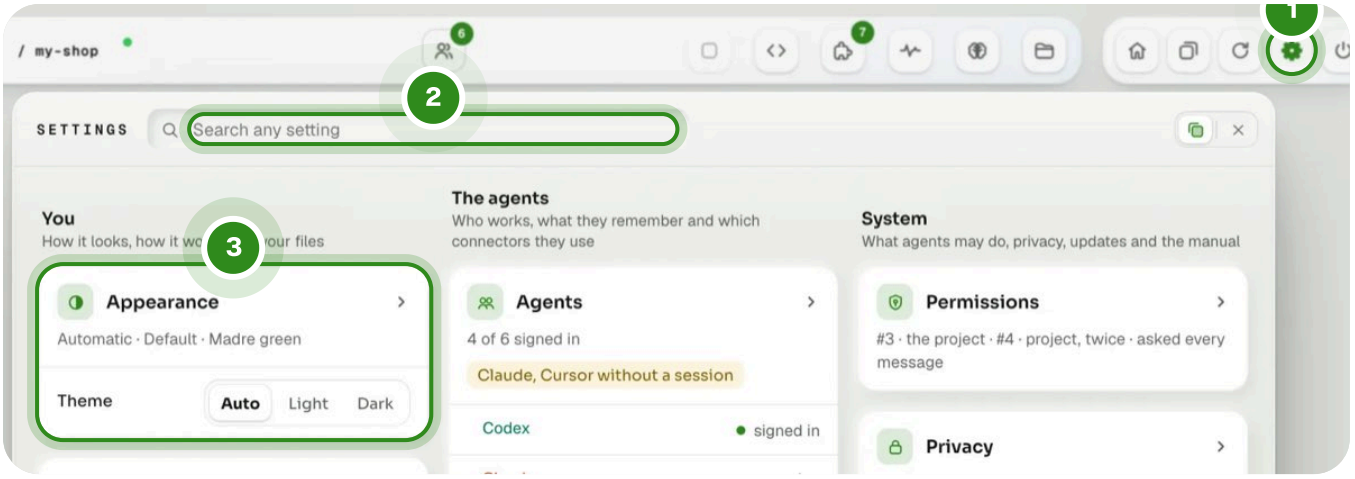
IF YOU KNOW THE BASICS

When you type in the box or in Code, the windows in the way step aside on their own.

16

Settings

Agents, permissions, appearance, memory and privacy are changed here.



1. Open them with the gear on the bar or with ⌘ ,.
2. Find any setting by its name.
3. Each card says how things stand before you open it. What you change saves on its own.

TRY IT

Type «accent» in the search and try another colour.

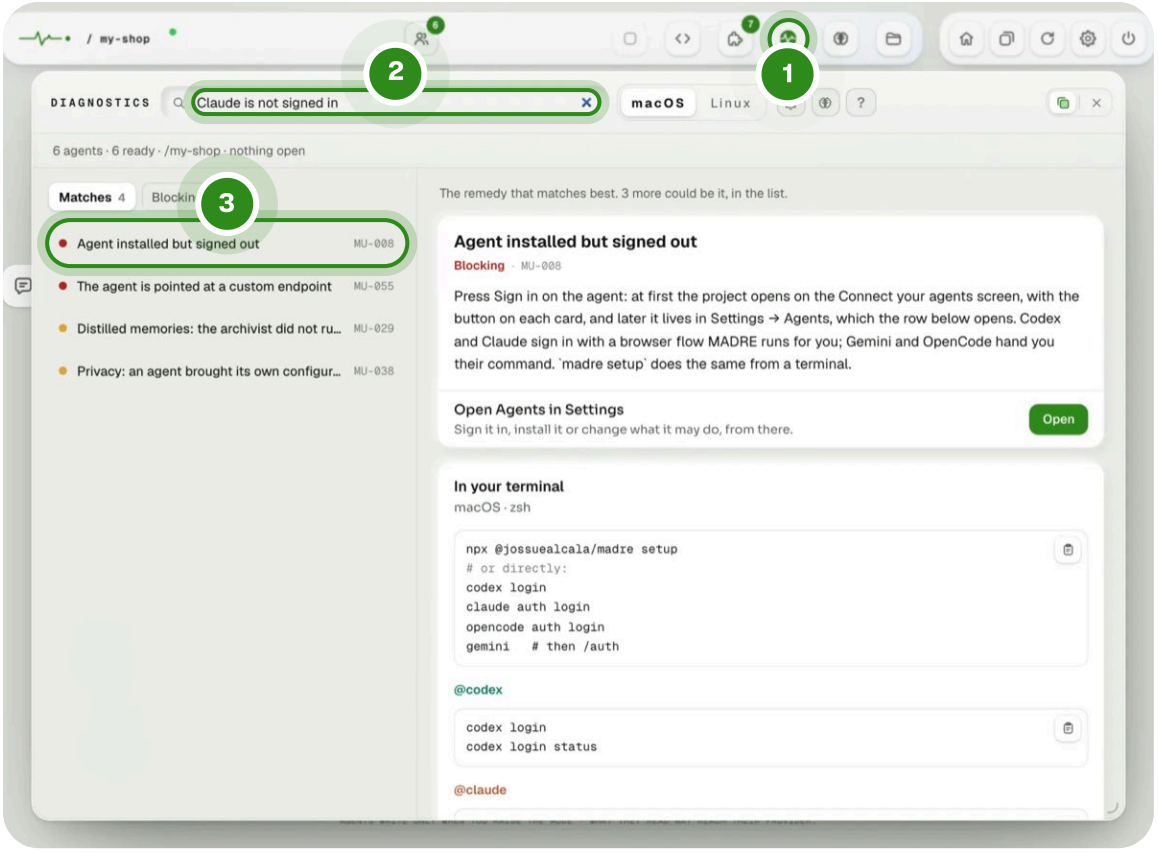
IF YOU KNOW THE BASICS

Each project can have its own colour and its own background.

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When something does not work

Diagnostics checks what is going on and gives you the key that fixes it, without leaving the project.



1. Press Diagnostics on the bar.
2. Write what you see, in your own words.
3. Open the case that looks like yours and do what it says.

TRY IT

If an agent asks you to sign in, open Diagnostics and write `Claude is not signed in`.

IF YOU KNOW THE BASICS

There you also see what left your Mac and where to, and how to turn each thing off. ? opens every shortcut on any screen.

18

Common problems

What happens most often and how to fix it. If yours is not here, open Diagnostics and write what you see.

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT TO DO
An agent says «Not signed in».	Settings › Agents: open it and press its key to sign in with your account.
MADRE does not find an agent.	Settings › Agents › Install. MADRE runs the command for you.
Gemini says it hit its limit (429) or is overloaded (503).	Wait a minute and ask again, pick another model in the model menu, or hand the question to another agent.
Gemini refuses your personal Google account.	Paste a Google AI Studio key in Settings › Agents › Gemini.
Cursor says its plan hit its limit.	It is your Cursor plan's limit, not MADRE's. Wait for it to renew or ask another agent.
«The API account has no credit left».	Top up that account or, in Settings › Agents, pick a model that uses your plan, such as ChatGPT or GitHub Copilot.
The agent did not answer in time.	Ask again. If it keeps happening, raise the time limit in Settings › Work and limits.
«The port is already in use».	Another MADRE is open: use that one, or open this one on another port with `npx @jossuealcala/madre --port 4800`.
The Terminal says your Node is too old.	Install Node 22.5 or newer from nodejs.org and run the command again.
An answer stopped because MADRE restarted.	Ask again. The chat was not lost.

IF YOU KNOW THE BASICS

Diagnostics works from the Terminal too: `npx @jossuealcala/madre doctor`.

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Every shortcut

Everywhere in MADRE

Settings

`⌘ ,`

Close what is on top, layer by layer

`Esc`

Stop everything

`/stopall`

Another tab when going to a project

`⌘ click`

This sheet

`?`

The bar

Order it

`right-click`

Remove a key

`-`

Move a key

`drag`

What does not fit

`•••`

Switch project

Open the panel

`click`

Move through it

`← → ↑ ↓`

Go

`click or ↵`

Close it

`Esc`

Windows and panels

Move

`drag the header`

ARRANGE

`hold the pointer 0.4 s`

All aside, or all back

`click the desktop`

Move aside what covers

`click or type`

Bring one back

`click its edge`

Panel width

`← → · ⇧ for 64 px`

The box

Send

`↵`

New line

`⌥ ↵`

Agent, mode, file, command

`@ # ! /`

Paste or drop images

`⌘ V`

Code

Find a file

`⌘ P`

Save

`⌘ S`

Find in the file

`⌘ F`

Comment the lines

`⌘ /`

Settings

Search

`/`

Open the first

`↵`

Back, layer by layer

`Esc`

Memory map

Turn

`drag`

Move

`⇧ drag`

Zoom

`wheel`

Read a memory

`click`

Project map

Move the space

`drag`

Go to one

`click · ← →`

Connect two

`carry one onto another`

Back

`Esc, layer by layer`

Home

A card's menu

`right-click`

Move a card

`drag`

Add cards and widgets

`right-click the background`

A project's menu

`right-click · ⋯`

Pin it

`drag to the bar`

Those that do not fit

`+n`

Viewer and editor

Save

`⌘ S`

Find · replace

`⌘ F · ⌥ ⌘ F`

Go to a line

`^ G`

MADRE is free software (AGPL v3). Help and news at madre.run.

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